SEVERE WEATHER REFERENCE

What alerts mean and what to do, hazard by hazard. Keep a copy where everyone can see it.

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GUIDE / VERIFY: General preparedness information, not a substitute for professional advice, local emergency-management instructions or manufacturer directions. Needs differ by household and location. **Verify important information with current official sources before relying on it.**

1. READING THE ALERTS

ALERT	WHAT IT MEANS	WHAT TO DO
Advisory	Weather that's a nuisance or could be hazardous if you're not careful.	Use caution.
Watch	Conditions are right for the hazard. It could happen.	**Get ready.** Review your plan; know where you'll go.
Warning	The hazard is happening or about to happen.	**Take action now.**

- **Wireless Emergency Alerts** come to your phone with a loud tone. Leave them turned on.
- **NOAA Weather Radio** broadcasts National Weather Service alerts all day, every day. A radio with an alert tone can wake you at night.
- Sign up for your county or city alerts.
- Outdoor sirens are meant for people outdoors. Don't count on hearing them inside.

2. HAZARD BY HAZARD

HAZARD	DURING	KNOW THIS
Tornado	Go to the lowest floor, to a small interior room without windows (closet, bathroom, hallway). Cover your head and neck. Mobile homes are not safe: go to a sturdy building.	Don't wait to see it. Many tornadoes are hidden by rain or darkness. Don't shelter under a highway overpass.
Flood / flash flood	Get to higher ground. Never walk, swim or drive through flood water. **Turn around, don't drown.**	6 inches of moving water can knock you down. 12 inches can carry away most cars; 2 feet can carry SUVs and trucks.
Thunderstorm / lightning	Go indoors or into a hard-topped car. Stay off corded phones and away from plumbing and windows.	**When thunder roars, go indoors.** Wait 30 minutes after the last thunder before going back out.
Hurricane	Evacuate if told to. Otherwise stay inside, away from windows, in an interior room.	Most hurricane deaths are from water: storm surge and inland flooding. Know your evacuation zone.
Winter storm / extreme cold	Stay indoors. Dress in layers. Avoid travel; if you must drive, carry a winter car kit. *(TR-09)*	Never heat your home with an oven, grill or generator. Watch for frostbite and hypothermia (below).
Extreme heat	Stay in air conditioning if you can. Drink water before you're thirsty. Limit outdoor work to early morning and evening.	Never leave anyone, or any pet, in a parked car. Check on older neighbors. Know where your cooling centers are.

Wildfire	Leave as soon as you're told to, or sooner. Keep N95 masks for smoke. Close windows and doors before you go.	Ready, Set, Go: have your go-bags ready during fire season, and keep your car fueled and facing out.
Earthquake	**Drop, cover and hold on.** Get under a sturdy table, or against an interior wall, covering your head and neck. Stay inside until the shaking stops.	Expect aftershocks. Check for gas leaks: if you smell gas, get out and call from outside.
Power outage	Use flashlights, not candles. Keep fridge and freezer closed. Unplug electronics.	Use generators outdoors only, at least 20 feet from windows, doors and vents. *(TR-07)*

3. HEAT AND COLD ILLNESS

CONDITION	SIGNS	WHAT TO DO
Heat exhaustion	Heavy sweating; cold, pale, clammy skin; fast, weak pulse; nausea; cramps; tiredness; dizziness; headache; fainting.	Move to a cool place. Loosen clothes; cool, wet cloths. Sip water. Get medical help if vomiting, or if it lasts more than an hour or gets worse.
Heat stroke	Body temperature 103°F or higher; hot, red, dry or damp skin; fast, strong pulse; headache; dizziness; confusion; passing out.	**Call 911. It's an emergency.** Move to a cooler place and cool the person with cool cloths or a cool bath. Don't give anything to drink.
Hypothermia	Shivering, exhaustion, confusion, fumbling hands, memory loss, slurred speech, drowsiness. Body temperature below 95°F.	Get medical help. Move to a warm place; remove wet clothes; warm the center of the body first with blankets and skin-to-skin contact. Warm drinks if awake (no alcohol).
Frostbite	Numb skin that looks white, grayish-yellow, or feels firm or waxy. Fingers, toes, nose, ears and cheeks.	Get to warmth. Use warm (not hot) water or body heat. Don't rub it, and don't use a heating pad, stove or fire: numb skin burns easily.

4. OUR LOCAL INFORMATION

Our county / parish: _____ **Tornado shelter spot at home:** _____

Local alert sign-up: _____ **Nearest cooling / warming center:** _____

NOAA Weather Radio frequency here: _____ **Nearest shelter:** _____

Evacuation zone: _____ **Higher ground / flood route:** _____

SOURCES / FURTHER REFERENCE

1. National Weather Service: Watch / Warning / Advisory; Turn Around Don't Drown; Lightning Safety; Tornado, Heat and Winter Safety. `weather.gov/safety`
2. FEMA: Ready.gov: hazard pages (tornadoes, floods, hurricanes, wildfires, earthquakes, extreme heat, winter weather, power outages). `ready.gov`
3. Centers for Disease Control and Prevention: Heat-Related Illnesses; Hypothermia and Frostbite. `cdc.gov/extreme-heat` `cdc.gov/winter-weather`
4. Earthquake Country Alliance / USGS: Drop, Cover and Hold On. `earthquakecountry.org`

IMPORTANT: Follow instructions from the National Weather Service and local officials. They have the latest information for where you are.